There was a second wave behind the first. Crouched on its back. Six feet higher, high enough to snatch me off my little hill. I scrabbled at the tree trunk again, but it was slick and gave me no purchase. I turned to face my doom. I saw people in the water. And houses. The Shompen boy had me by the shoulders, hauling me into the neem tree. Then I was in the branches. Cowering behind a sheet of leaves, as if they could shield me from anything. What did it matter? The wave would surely uproot the tree. We would both be dead in a few seconds.

Why did the narrator sob in selfish relief?

9. The Shompen boy squatted beside me, apparently calm. His eyes were wide, but his body was relaxed and casual. He knew that there was nothing more to do. Whatever happened was beyond our control. What happened was that we survived. The wave flowed inland for what seemed like an eternity, but it never managed to uproot our ancient tree. The hill became a little island on the back of our sunken island, and the Shompen boy and I were the only two inhabitants. Things flowed beneath us that nobody should ever see. The sea had claimed its bounty, and now it was revealing it to me. Shacks, bicycles, livestock, and of course people. My heart was torn from my chest as I saw a girl I knew float past, her beautiful dark hair trailing behind her. I think she was a distant cousin. She was encased in driftwood and rubbish, like something lost and worthless. I will never forget that image. I have thought about her so much since that day that I feel she is known to me now, much more than in life.

10. A sharp pain in my arm cut through the dull pain of despair. I looked down. The Shompen boy was twisting a corkscrew thorn from my forearm. I jerked away, then pulled at the thorn myself, but the boy gripped my hand firmly. 'Not pull,' he said, in his thick accent. 'Turn. Pull makes a big hole.' He gripped the thorn again, twisting it gently so that it followed its own path out. The tip was covered with half an inch of my blood. I almost felt sorry for myself, but then I remembered that I was alive to feel pain. My distant cousin was not. And what of my family? Mama and Papa. My God, what of them? I wanted to jump down from our tree and run to the village. But all I could see were treetops and water. The wave still covered the ground and it was moving in fast muscular currents. If my parents were alive, they would not want me to kill myself. So, I was stuck here for the time being, at the mercy of a pickpocket Shompen savage. A savage who had saved my life, and fixed my arm.

Why did he decide to stay on the tree and not go in search of his parents?

(Abridged from Fire Stones -EOIN COLFER)

This is an excerpt from: http://www.thehindu.com/mag/2005/12/25/stories



Glossary

bluefin (n): a type of tuna fish

retreat (v): move back from a position, withdraw

horizon (n): the point at which the earth and the sky seem to meet

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